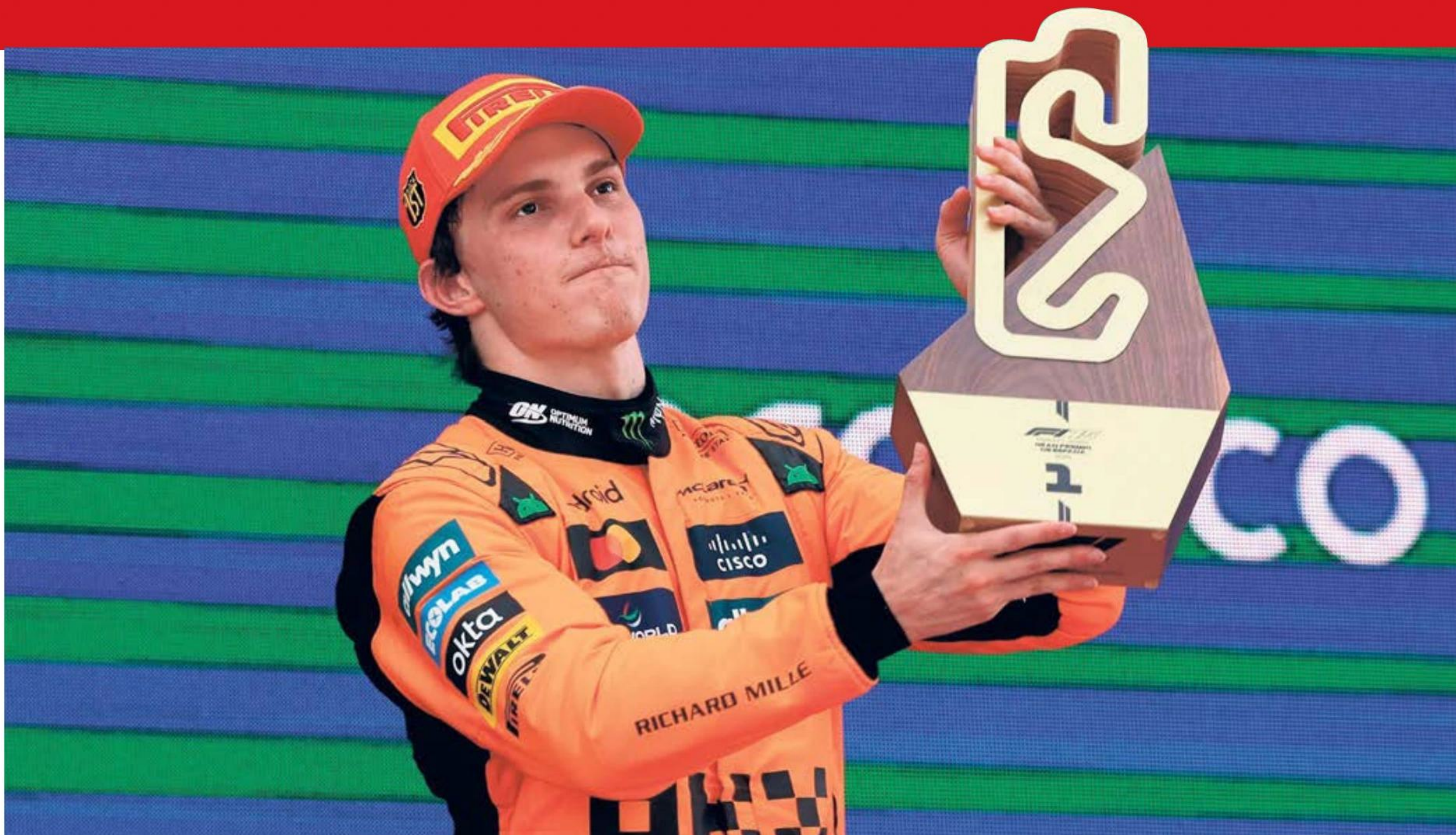




Piastri ticks off Spain win

Just three points separated the McLaren duo atop the standings, with the team's dominance in the constructors' table cementing its status as favourite in Barcelona.

The Spanish Grand Prix, the final stop of another gruelling triple-header, seemed the ideal setting to end the team's 20-year winless streak at this venue.

As in Monaco, a front-row start in Spain is often half the battle, and McLaren had both drivers leading the pack. To the disappointment of previous winner Norris, it was Piastri who snatched pole with a commanding lap. However, the Max Verstappen threat loomed large from third on the grid.

The Red Bull ace made quick work of Norris but couldn't quite match the McLarens on raw pace. Banking on aggression, Red Bull went with a three-stop strategy, giving Verstappen the licence to push hard on fresher tyres. The gamble had begun to work until it all went downhill.

Norris, who had regained his place later on, had the Red Bull in his rear-view mirror just as they began to lap the slower cars. But a Safety Car upended everything —

the entire field got a cheap pit stop. Verstappen's earlier stops were nullified, and the advantage dissipated.

With fresher tyres and track position, it was advantage McLaren once again. Piastri nailed the restart, Norris followed, and Verstappen fell into the clutches of Ferrari's Leclerc. Battling both the scarlet red competitor and his own car, the Dutchman's podium hopes faded quickly.

His frustration peaked with a clash involving George Russell, earning him a 10-second penalty and three penalty points. He slumped to a disappointing tenth, losing further ground to the runaway McLaren pair.

Piastri claimed his fifth win of the season, leading McLaren to its third 1-2 finish in nine races — its first in Spain since Mika Hakkinen and David Coulthard in 2000. Leclerc, continuing his comeback trail from Monaco with his third podium, offering a rare bright spot for Ferrari.

As the F1 bandwagon heads to Canada for round 10, McLaren sits firmly in control.

And with Piastri and Norris separated by 10 points, the championship fight is increasingly shaping up as a two-way race.

Quartararo moments before. Marc remained close to Alex for most of the race, but he was never allowed to bounce back.

Alex fittingly ended his brother's perfect record in this year's sprint races, guiding his Gresini Ducati to the finish line.

But on Sunday, it was Marco Bezzecchi (**left**) who starred, acing a masterclass in tyre management to win the Grand Prix for Aprilia — a long-awaited achievement in this dismal season without defending champion Jorge Martin, who recently announced his decision to leave the side.

Bezzecchi executed a soft-tyre gamble impeccably to take the chequered flag ahead of Johann Zarco and championship leader Marc. The Ducati rider, scoring consistently so far, enjoys a 24-point lead over Alex, who finished fifth.

